

Game Link: <https://krishnarishik.github.io/Hex/>

GitHub Link: <https://github.com/KrishnaRishik/Hex>

Question 2: Gameplay Insights & Strategy

An overdue-for-reinvention genre: durable social deduction

The genre: the Mafia/Werewolf lineage, free-to-play, mobile.

Among Us is one of the most popular mobile games in 2020. It went from near-zero to one of the most-played games on earth in months, then fell almost as fast. The game was constant with no change but it got boring fast, the appetite for lying to your friends is permanent. Mafia has worked at sleepovers for decades. Nobody had built a mobile game that brought out the essence of mafia and **engineered to keep** it. Among Us had the brilliance of a party toy and the retention too.

Three structural reasons the genre still hasn't been cracked:

1. **The empty-lobby problem.** Deduction needs a full room of humans, right now, to function. Off-peak, in a small region, or for a new player at 2am, the lobby is dead, leaving players waiting for hours just to start the game. You can't even solo for five minutes while you wait.
2. **Nothing to sell.** The concept of the game revolves around social interaction in the game, not progression. There is no gear, no power, nothing that the players would want to move towards, barely a metagame. The only honest monetization is cosmetics.
3. **Toxicity.** Lying to strangers curdles fast when it hits the wrong spot or the wrong person, reputation is damaged and importantly it could lead to conflicts and harassment, there is no proper moderation which a quick-match party game should have.

What a breakout would actually take

Kill the empty lobby with believable AI players. A match should be instant and full at any hour, in any region, for a brand-new player. If the search takes more than 5 minutes, the lobby can be filled with agents good enough to accuse, defend, and deceive convincingly. This is the single biggest unlock, and it's only recently become possible. Although deceiving AI isn't always as satisfying as fooling a real person, so the system should still prioritize humans, auto-switching regions and adding cross play to widen the player search, with AI as the fallback that keeps the lobby instant.

Monetize identity and creators, not power. Cosmetic personas, a creator economy for custom roles and maps, seasonal social events, a player membership which allows the player to create separate rooms and game mode and release on a marketplace for other players to try.

One of my favorite mobile f2p games is Genshin Impact, If I could steal one feature from this game, it would be the cadence, the game rewards the player after completion of each activity. This not only motivates players to continue playing but also encourages the players to spend their rewards towards items in game.